What the World Needs Now

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Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), All the canon ships

Characters:
Hordak (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Castaspella (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Emily (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Angst, Post-Canon, Post-War, Imperialism, Aftermath of Violence, Hurt/Comfort, Damaged People Being Damaged

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English

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Part 1 of Season of the Survivor

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by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

Love isn’t the only thing that there’s just too little of. What the world needs now that Prime's gone is... well, a lot of things. Decades of global war do not a stable planet make. But Etheria survived. Adora loves Catra, and Hordak is in Bright Moon. The planet is full war victims who have suffered decades of devastating warfare. The planet is also full of war villains, who are alive and well in a landscape that hates them. But everyone has grown so much and come so far, some are practically different people, all living in a totally different world. Now they have to figure out how to build an Etheria they can all stand to share. Now it's time for sympathy and forgiveness, and survivor solidarity. Now they have to grow new from the ashes of the old, and invent the future as they build it.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

”So are we all just, like, okay with this?” Mermista asked, looking over her shoulder at Entrapta and the clone that Prime had possessed as they wandered off across a lush meadow that, moments before, had been a barren canyon.

“Okay with what?” Sea Hawk asked before he spotted the retreating duo.

“I know that’s only her second clone, but she can’t just keep adopting them.” Mermista said, maintaining her skeptical expression.

“Maybe She-Ra accidentally scrambled his brains like Bow did to Wrong Hordak,” Frosta suggested as she laughed and swung off one of Scorpia’s giant claws and Perfuma clung to the other affectionately.

“Maybe ,” Mermista said slowly, “but it might start getting weird if she collects any more.”

“Entrapta does Entrapta. It’ll be fine,” Scorpia said dismissively through a wide grin. “There’s no stopping her, so you may as well watch her go.”

“Entrapta can take care of herself, trust me.” Micah agreed, bending his neck forward as Castaspella examined the raw, scarred patch of skin Prime’s chip had fallen from.

“Whatever she’s up to, she’s earned it,” Castaspella said admiringly, releasing her brother. “She disabled all of Prime’s chips."

“Wow, yeah,” Mermista agreed, rubbing the back of her own neck. “Yeah, she has earned it.” Sea Hawk wrapped his arms around her and threatened a shanty before she pushed him away good-naturedly.

“All of this new flora and fauna,” Perfuma cried in rapture, having broken from Scorpia to twirl merrily through the glowing dust on

the air. She stopped with her arms out and heaved a giant breath in, eyes closed and smile wide. Then she stopped and her eyes popped open. “I wonder if this happened everywhere or just here.”

“It was probably just where She-Ra was,” Scorpia offered, “I can’t imagine the fright Zone looking green. I haven’t seen so much as a front lawn there since I was a little kid. And what about the Crimson Waste? No way did that whole place transform.

“I don’t know about that,” Netossa said, pointing up into the sky where one of Primes Ships now seemed to have become a cluster of gigantic trees, looming just above their atmosphere.

“Oh wow, would you look at that,” Scorpia said, looking stunned.

“Dearest?” Sea Hawk asked a newly worried-looking Mermista. Is something the matter?”

“Mermista, we won!” Frosta encouraged, joy undampened.

“For sure, yeah,” she said, trying to shake herself. “I’m just thinking about… clean up. You know?”

“Ew, why?” Frosta asked before Spinnerella nudged her.

“I just don’t think that a bunch of new gigantic magical plants and animals are going to make rebuilding Etheria any easier,” Mermista said, chewing her bottom lip for a moment. The rest of the group exchanged glances, smiles faltering. “But,” she said, rousing herself and giving the others a bracing smile. “Frosta’s right. We won. Prime is gone, and I can’t wait to go home and get back to life with my people.”

“That’s my girl!” Sea Hawk boomed, clapping her on the back while Frosta cheered and Perfuma clapped her hands.

“Although,” Mermista continued, giving Perfuma an apologetic look. “I’m probably going to need some of your help with… this,”

she said, waving a hand vaguely at the unfamiliar landscape around them.

"Of course!" Perfuma said, eyes squeezing shut because she was smiling so hard.

"And maybe us too, by the looks of it," Netossa said, exchanging a glance with Spinnerella.

"Oh man, if this is a global thing.. " Scorpia trailed off, laughing nervously.

"I'm… I'm sure we can work it out in no time with *teamwork*," Castaspella said. Micah cringed at the strain in her tone.

A loud, deep-throated roar echoed from nearby and they exchanged nervous glances. "We might need She-Ra for a little bit, too," Perfuma laughed nervously.

"Good thing she's got that super-fast spaceship!" cried Swift Wind, wandering nearer, followed closely by Wrong Hordak, who was looking around himself in apparent distress.

"What's, uh, wrong, Wrong Hordak?" Perfuma asked kindly.

"Wrong who?" Micah asked, looking at the clone warily.

"I am… concerned. About my brothers," he said, ears down and brows pinched. As the others looked around themselves, they realized that the clones who had been surrounding them on the battlefield hadn't gone far. They were starting to cluster up and break down in varying states of emotional turmoil.

"Uh…" Mermista interjected, "what's going on right now? I know they lost, but…"

Frosta groaned and looked at Wrong Hordak. "What are we supposed to do with them now?"

"Oh dear," Perfuma said with darting eyes. "This is quite the problem. This is… an enormous problem. Oh my, there's… so many of them."

"Well, all of the clones that were here, like, *here* here, saw She-Ra defeat Prime, so maybe we should get her to talk to them?" Scorpia suggested.

"Speaking of She-Ra, where did those kids get off to?" Micah said. "I want to hang out with my daughter more and we still have work to do."

As if on cue, the four missing heroes came meandering back, talking and laughing, trailed by Melog.

"Adora!" Swift Wind cried out. "Come help us plan our super awesome future together!" he said exuberantly, "and help us figure out what to do with literal thousands of Wrong Hordak's emotionally devastated brothers," he gave a nervous laugh as he eyed Wrong Hordak and his growing agitation.

Glimmer grabbed Bow's hand and Adora wrapped her arm around Catra's shoulders before answering. "Let's do this," she said, looking at Catra instead of Swift Wind.

"Ugh," Frosta groaned again, "This is going to be about supply lines and aid strategies, isn't it?"

Catra stopped in her tracks and looked around them. "Wow. *Wow*. Yeah, now that I'm thinking more about it, all the obnoxious little details it takes to keep a place running are still a mess." She sucked air through gritted teeth and pressed a hand to her forehead. "Shit, this is a bureaucratic nightmare!"

"Does that mean we have to postpone the road trip?" Adora asked in confusion.

"Wow. Catra the bureaucrat," Glimmer teased before heaving a sigh. "Do we really have to be talking about this right now? I knew there'd be a lot of work even after it was over, but we've

been fighting for so long.” A note of true weariness entered her tone. "And She-Ra can like, channel all Etheria's healing powers."

Micah put a hand on her shoulder. “I know, and all of you have been so brave, and so strong.” He put his other hand on Adora’s shoulder and made meaningful eye contact with as many people as possible. “You’ve done such amazing things here and you deserve to rest, but we still have a few more things to do before our people can rest with us.”

“You’re right, you’re right,” Glimmer said, placing her hand over his on her shoulder.

“But Prime is gone. We can celebrate that, even if we can’t rest yet,” Bow said.

“We probably shouldn’t take time to celebrate before we even take account of what the people need first,” interjected Adora, predictably.

“Uh guys?” Swift Wind had sidled over to Wrong Hordak, who wringing his hands but scowling determinedly. “The clones? They don’t look like they’re in great shape.”

“Right,” Glimmer broke in with a compromise, speaking with clipped determination. “You guys figure out how to approach them to explain the situation while I gather people at Bright Moon with my… my dad, both for a little celebration and to start setting up shelter for everybody that needs it. Then, we party together for a little bit... maybe this includes cake, maybe it doesn’t... then everybody goes home tonight to connect with their officials and gather information.” She paused to draw breath. “That way, we can meet back here tomorrow morning bright and early and make a plan to start fixing things.”

“Why can’t the clones shelter in the spires? I think that’s what they were already doing,” suggested Castaspella.

Catra felt goosebumps crawl up her arms and she and Glimmer exchanged quick looks before the other spoke again. “I, uh, I

don’t want them to be around Prime any more than they have to be. The inside of those things… I just don’t want them to have to stay there.” Several people exchanged confused glances.

“Uh, how are people supposed to get all the way home and back by morning?” Scorpia asked.

“Oh yeah,” Glimmer said. “What if I teleported the princesses?”

“Glimmer, you’re as tired as we are and you’re about to throw a party. That doesn’t seem realistic,” said Bow, reasonably.

“What about Darla?” Catra asked.

“Oh, yeah, I bet Entrapta could get everybody home in a flash!” Glimmer said. “Where is she?” They all began to look around them expectantly.

“Last we saw she was headed that direction, arm in arm with that poor bastard Prime was in,” said Mermista with a raised eyebrow. Catra felt Adora shift on her feet uncomfortably.

“We’ll find her later,” Glimmer said, “right now, it’s time for cake.”

“Ready to start dismantling this corrupt regime and help bring justice to the universe, buddy?” Swift Wind asked Wrong Hordak, who nodded and squared his shoulders.

“How about you?” Catra asked Adora. “You literally just almost died. Do you, uh, need a minute or something?”

The terror of what they’d just been through flickered behind Adora’s eyes for a moment, but only for a moment. Then she was staring at Catra, eyes blazing with the thrill of victory. “Later. We’ll take a minute later. Right now, I just want to see everyone alive and happy.” She lifted a hand to the side of Catra’s face and she leaned into the caress. She paused for a moment, but didn’t move her hand away. “Are you sure you love me? That wasn’t just to keep me from skipping out on my promise?”

Catra stepped forward to kiss Adora. Properly this time, instead of that horrified, adrenaline-fueled swan song bullshit from before. "I've loved your dumb ass since we were kids," she said, smiling against her mouth. "And even if you didn't mean it when you said you loved me too, I'm holding you to it."

"Of course I mea-mpht…" Adora tried to answer, but Catra shut her up with another kiss, lingering until she realized Frosta was staring at them with a disgusted expression.

* * * * *

It was several hours later when Entrapta and Hordak came to a stop not far from the battlefield where they'd first begun walking aimlessly as Hordak listened to Entrapta. She told him about her time on Beast Island, her brief journey in space, and her success in breaking Prime's hold on the minds of Etherians around the world. All the while, he'd stared down at her animated features, marveling. Part of him refused to believe it was real, instead waiting for Prime to freeze the simulation and begin laughing cruelly. But he didn't. The only voice he heard in real life was Entrapta's.

When Hordak had shed the arm canon she'd been clinging to, he expected her to settle into examining it. Instead, she let it fall and grasped onto his forearm and hand instead. The contact jolted Hordak more firmly into the present, and for a moment he split his attention from her face to take account of reality around him. It was so disorienting that he had to keep reminding himself- insisting to himself- that everything was, indeed, real.

After he'd briefly surveyed the empty woods around them, he focused on Entrapta's words again. She'd caught him up on everything she'd learned and worked on since they'd last seen each other, stopping every now and then to offer kind instruction to a distraught clone, telling them that aid would likely be gathered at political centers and pointing them toward Bright Moon. Now as she spoke, she circled back to elaborate on how she'd used Wrong Hordak to access data on a planet called Krytis.

Krytis. He'd heard her say the word 'Krytis' hours before and he'd had a pit in his stomach ever since. Now as she explained Prime's cover-up and Wrong Hordak's subsequent breakdown, Hordak forced himself to think and speak again. "Lies…" Hordak said without meaning to, stopping Entrapta's flow of chatter. "It really was all lies after all. All... *all* of it?"

Entrapta tilted his chin toward her with a piece of hair. "Hordak, even if you didn't know about Krytis, are you really surprised? Do you remember having doubts?"

He clenched his fists. "I'm not surprised," he said bitterly, "and that is the crux of my failure." In response to her furrowed brow and cocked head he continued, "Entrapta, if I had doubts- and I did by the end- it means that I knew on some level…" He struggled to find the right words. "I knew something wasn't right, but I remained loyal anyway." He looked away and pressed his fingers to his temples. "I was so close to calling the portal off," he hissed, eyes wide with burgeoning horror. "That's what took so damn long between getting the sword and pulling the lever… I almost called it off."

"I knew it," she said quietly to herself with a small smile. When she noticed his distress, she continued. "Wait, so why didn't you investigate your doubts?"

He thought hard, trying to pin down an answer to her simple question. "Because I am a coward," he finally said.

"Huh?"

“I…,” he grunted in frustration, “something about you felt so… so true . … And yet… I was weak, and I was afraid, and I chose the easier path instead of examining my crumbling faith.”

“I don’t think being scared of Prime makes you a coward,” Entrapta said quietly, her expression softened.

He laughed, cold and bitter. “You wouldn’t say that if you’d been there while I groveled at his feet.”

She sighed and squared up in front of him. “Now you’re just being stubborn. Don’t beat yourself up for what Prime did to you. It’s erroneous and counterproductive.” Her stern expression faltered, and she lost her authoritative bearing and looked down. “Also,” she said, “I thought about it a lot, and I’m sorry if I pushed you further than what you were ready for. I’m sorry if I added to the confusion,” she mumbled haltingly.

He sighed heavily. “Do not apologize. My decisions were my own.” He moved to clutch the crystal in his left pocket and felt a troubling tightness in his shoulder, arm, and side.

“So,” Entrapta suggested slowly, “it was rough there for a while, but it turns out you were actually right to be so confused. You don’t have to feel bad about betraying him,” she smiled up at him hopefully, “You helped free so many people today. You freed yourself, too.”

Hordak didn’t respond at first. He had been stunned and frightened by the magnitude of his betrayal initially, but once Prime had forced him to watch his own hands hurting Entrapta, any trace of regret had vanished. What disturbed him about Entrapta’s words- what filled his gut with frozen, heavy dread- was that they confirmed his darkest fears; every single awful thing he’d tried to dismiss or ignore for terror of being wrong. He had taken refuge in zealousness, never allowed himself to consider the horrific alternative to the presumed righteousness of his path. He had always been a coward and had lived his life in denial. “It was all for nothing,” he whispered. “It was all for nothing.”

"I… well now hang on there," she began, looking concerned. Just as she began to continue, Adora came running their way, followed closely by Catra.

He barely noticed as they caught their breath. He simply stared down at Entrapta, who smiled at them, competely caught up in his burgeoning mental turmoil. Catra spoke first. "No fair... You've been doing cardio while I've been stuck in space."

"Still won," smiled Adora, puffing hard as she placed her hands on her hips.

Catra turned to address Entrapta. "You made Darla go really fast. Do you think you and Wrong Hordak could get all the princesses home tonight for some business, then get them all back here in the morning? For, uh.. more business?"

Entrapta cackled and shook her fists in delight. "You bet! Ooooh mini road trip, come on!" she began to tow Hordak away, but this time he resisted. "What's wrong?" she asked, looking around at him.

"I… Forgive me but, I need some time to think," he said, instinctively drawing away from the three women before him.

"Uh oh," Entrapta said, "we might have another existential crisis coming on." Catra gave them both a pained look.

"No, I…" Hordak shook his head as if to clear it. "You attend to your duties. I am fine." He patted the gloved hand that still held his wrist and tried to imagine how to create a reassuring expression with his facial features.

"I don't know…" Entrapta said, looking concerned again. "I really don't want to get separated."

"You guys can meet back up after the ride on the *spaceship*," Catra suggested. Entrapta immediately brightened and let go of Hordak.

"Truly. I could use some time to rest and gather my thoughts, anyway. Go help your friends," he insisted, glancing up at Catra nervously. She was squinting at him and he got the distinct impression that she knew exactly who he was.

"If you're sure," Entrapta said before reluctantly stepping away.

"Come on, everybody's been missing you," Adora said.

"They want to thank you for everything you did, and Frosta is dying for a ride on Darla," Catra added.

"Really?" Entrapta asked, then started off in the direction they'd come from. "I'll find you later, then. I promise!" she called over her shoulder. He barely registered that Adora and Catra both chose to remain silent as they turned and followed her.

Hordak stood mutely and watched them disappear over the hill before sinking onto the ground. The pain he'd known when he realized Entrapta was lost to him was a grief even more profound than what he'd felt when he'd been banished to Despondos. The agony of losing someone he didn't want to live without… how many beings had he inflicted that pain upon? Thousands... it had to be thousands or more. But this was just a figure, a number, disconnected with the reality of pain behind the statistics... but whether it felt true to him or not, the facts were plain to see. Everything he'd ever known, every conviction he'd ever held, every sacrifice he'd ever made, every deed he had ever performed… it was all for nothing. All for the empty promises of a false god.

Hordak wrapped his arms tightly around himself and focused on not shaking. What was even worse yet… it still wasn't over. Hordak knew war, and he knew its aftermath. Etheria was in for brutal lessons in disillusionment and disappointment.

His hearts constricted in his chest as he thought of the global turmoil that would continue to stain every Ehterian life, including Entrapta's. Considering the scale of the damage and involvement

of Horde forces everywhere, the world was now packed with war victims, all with righteous cries for justice that, should they go unanswered, would fill Etheria with unrest and bitterness. Would they demand punishment for Entrapta because of what she'd done in and for the horde? Even if her friends spared her, what kind of relationship with her home could she hope for? How would the people treat her? How would her work suffer?

Panic and horror rose within him in equal measure. This wasn't over. He wasn't finished yet, he couldn't be. No matter why he'd done the things he'd done, the damage was inescapable and Entrapta would suffer because of it.

Unless…

Unless he could do something to stop it. He thought about it for a moment and, yes, he might have the power to fix it for her, to finally help her instead of hold her back. He might just be able to do something right for once in his pathetic life.

As he continued to consider the situation, however, doubt seeped through him. Every memory that was coming back painted a darker picture of his many crimes, especially by Etherian standards. He didn't want to think about it, but the true scope of the situation directly concerned Entrapta, and everything was all his fault. So he examined the memories, image by image, trying to keep a mental ledger of the wounds that Etheria would still be bleeding from, and what would have to be done to placate the people without further conflict. It wasn't long before he was overwhelmed, bile in his throat and claws digging into his own scalp at the roots of his hair.

He wasn't big enough to fix this. He was powerless. Powerless, again and forever. How could he do anything to help her? But… what else could he do, other than try? He had to try. He had to do everything he could to try and shield her from the consequences of his failures.

Then he thought for a moment about the Fright Zone and its many full barracks. He had been the one to command their deeds, but Etherians would be out for their blood regardless. The ramifications of that kind of bloodshed between fellow Etherians would ensure suffering and strife for decades, if not generations. If he had been a defeated local militant answering to a victorious Prime, he'd be held responsible for those in his command. In a victorious Etheria, he might still have a chance at shielding his forces from the consequences of his past.

And he would likely only have one chance to do it right. He needed to think and he needed to plan, but first he needed to get ahold of himself and focus on assessing the damage they were dealing with.

End Notes

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.
Centered around Catra and Hordak. Aged up significantly for super adult themes, but it's still set in the canon universe so truth spells are a thing and the only sociopath involved was Prime.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!